

Creative & Effective Presentations in PowerPoint



Digital Integration Teaching Initiative (DITI)

Taught by TBD

Dr. Carolin Fuchs

GRMN1101 | Summer 2026

Workshop Agenda & Outline

- Learn guidelines, best practices, and tips for making a PowerPoint presentation
- Learn how to include audio clips (voice over) in your PowerPoint
- Learn how to consider accessibility in designing presentations.
- Explore options for advanced design

Link to module materials:

Getting Started: The Basics

Introduction to PowerPoint

- Microsoft PowerPoint is a presentation program for Windows, Mac, or mobile devices.
- You can use it to create presentations from scratch or from a template
- Users can add text, images, and videos; use professional designs with PowerPoint Designer; and add transitions, animations, and motion. Presentations can be saved to OneDrive and shared with others.
- If you are a member of the Northeastern community, PowerPoint is available with [Northeastern's Microsoft 365 subscription](#). See: [installation instructions for Mac](#) and [instructions for Windows](#).

Organize your Presentation

- Treat your presentation like any other form of argument, explanation, or narrative— be intentional, and **organize your slides carefully!**
- **Put main ideas front-and-center on the slides.** Additional detail can go in the “Notes” section.
- **Use signposts** to orient your audience.

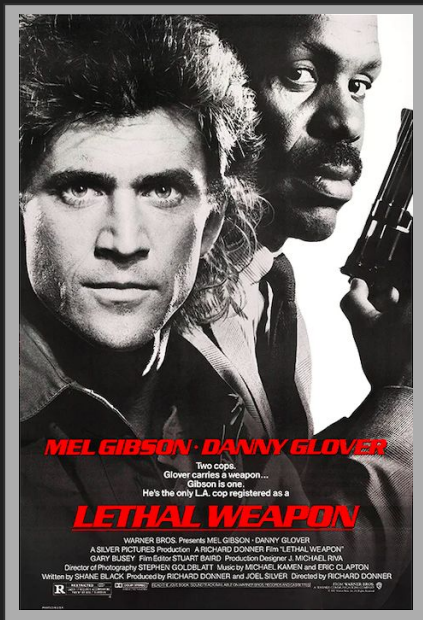
Keep it Simple

- **Less is more.**
- Slides should be **clear, concise**, and above all, **understandable**.
- Nothing in your slide should be superfluous, ever!
- Slides need plenty of “negative space.”

Compare the two slides that follow. Which do you think is more effective? Why?

Blockbuster Movie Posters: Then vs Now

1987



Core characters

Single shot with minimal editing

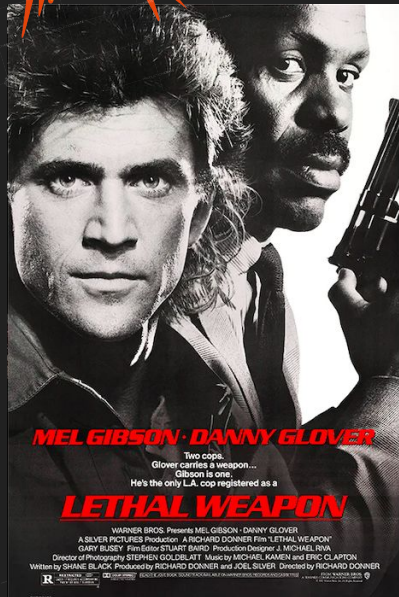
2023



Most, if not all, named characters

Distinct headshots digitally superimposed

Blockbuster Movie Poster Design Trends Have Changed Greatly Over 40 Years



1987

Posters that once featured only core characters originally posed in a single shot frame have now become posters that feature most if not all named characters presented through distinct headshots superimposed during post-editing. This reflects a film industry that has fallen into deeper and deeper dependence on digital technology for the benefit of production efficiency. Personally I find it a loss in the artistic merit of these marketing objects which possibly reflects a similar artistic loss in the films themselves. In this way the change in how posters get made functions as a metonymy for how the film industry as a whole has evolved. The use of *Mission: Impossible - Dead Reckoning Part One* here is in a way ironic, since lately Tom Cruise's entire career seems to revolve around an implicit critique of the very digital overdependence his own film's poster perfectly reflects. It's hard to say, then, to what degree I can take this critique seriously regardless of how many cliffs he drives a motorcycle off of.

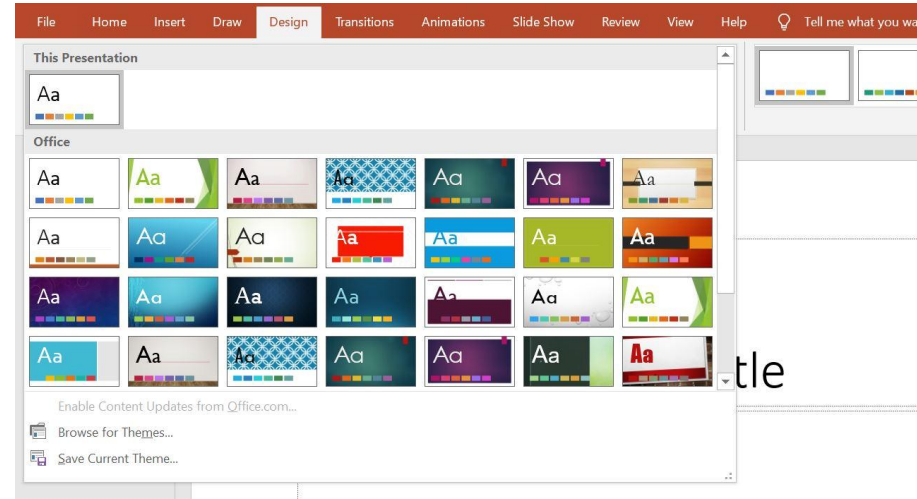


2023

Getting Started: Presentation Design and Master Slides

Design: Select Theme

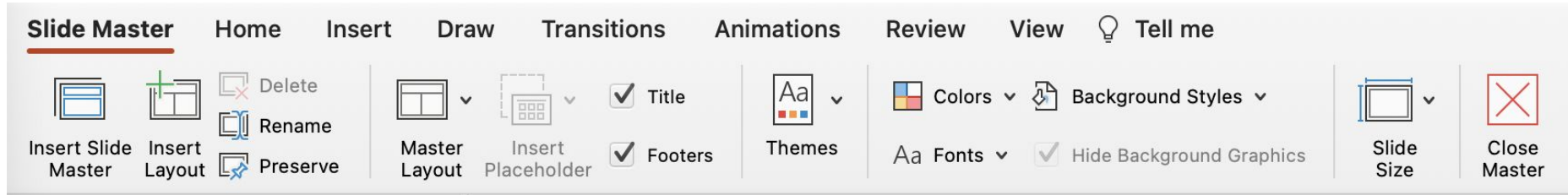
- Design templates contain color schemes, slide and title masters with custom formatting, and styled fonts.
 - Select the **Design** tab.
 - Select one of the **Themes**—click on the down arrow with a line over it for the drop-down menu.
 - Select one of the **Variants**.



Master Slides

Master Slides provide your presentation with a consistent and professional look.

To set up Master Slides, go into “View” and choose “Slide Master” from the “Master” menu.



Master Slide Templates

Click to edit Master title style

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level

6/4/21

Footer

Click to edit Master title style

Click to edit Master text styles

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level



Click to edit Master title style

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level



6/4/21

Footer

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level



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Footer

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Presentation Tips: Text

Keep it Visible: Fonts

- Sans serif fonts are typically the best for presentations.
- Be generous with spacing.
- No more than two complementary fonts (e.g., Arial and **Arial Bold** for emphasis).
- Use mixed case, not all CAPS.
- **Bold** vs. Underline vs. *Italics*.

Times New Roman: Keep it Visible

EB Garamond: Keep it Visible

Arial: Keep it Visible

Droid Sans: Keep it Visible

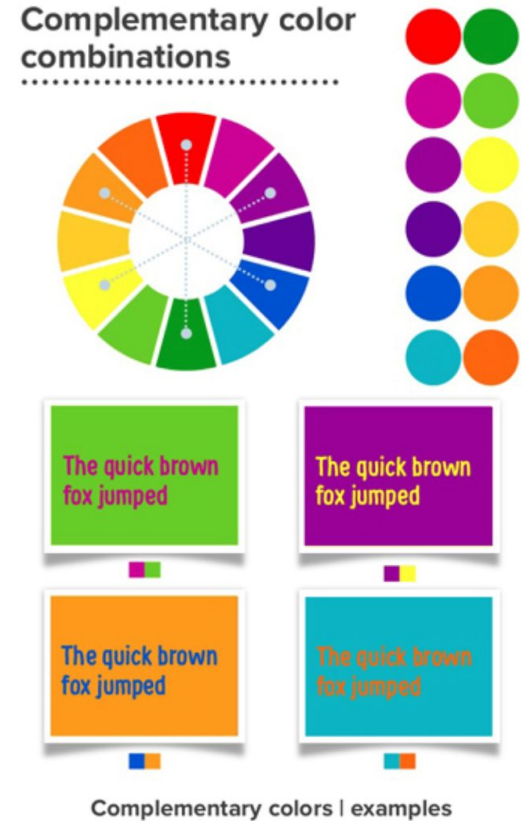
Caveat: Keep it Visible

Comic: Keep it Visible

Cambria: Keep it Visible

Keep it Visible: Colors

- Make color choices that are accessible to everyone (and appropriate for the presentation).
- Ideal color schemes are **high contrast**.
 - Limit your palette to 3 colors total.
 - PowerPoint offers multiple color palettes.
 - [NU Colors](#) offers a university palette.

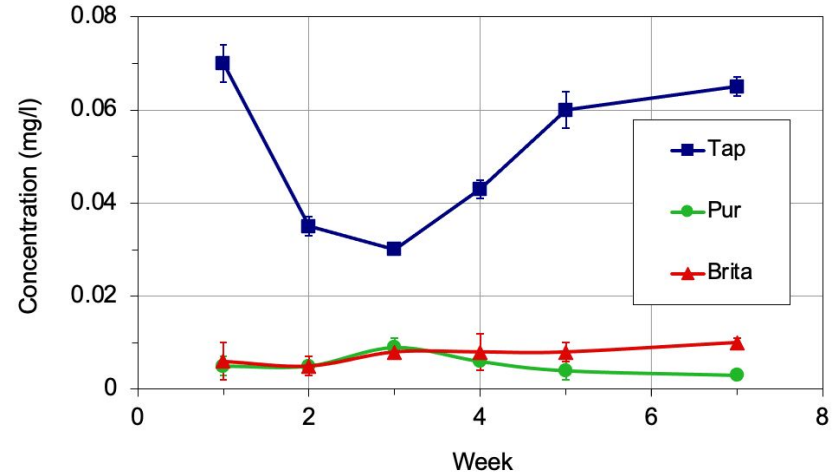
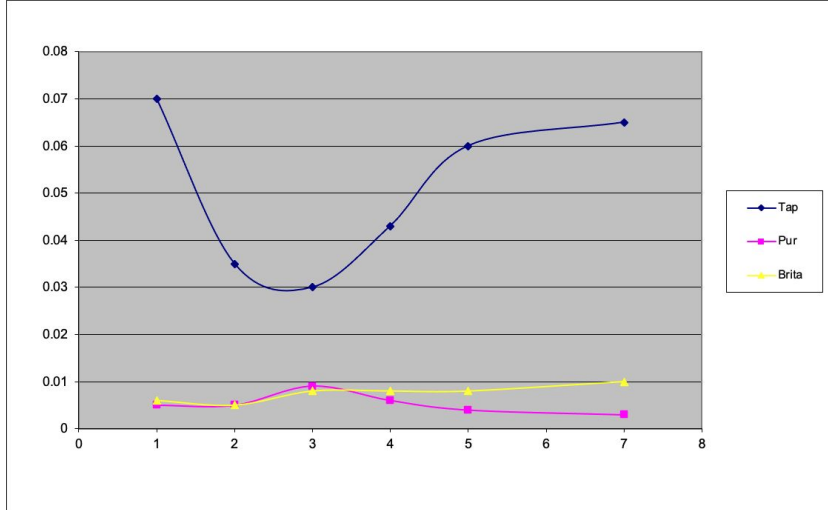


Presentation Tips: Images

Use Graphics & Charts

- Graphs and charts are a great way to communicate complex information.
- You can add many kinds of charts to your presentation:
 - Bar charts, trend lines, pie charts, scatter plots, spider charts, and more.
- The graphics and charts should be of high-quality, accurate, and self-explanatory.

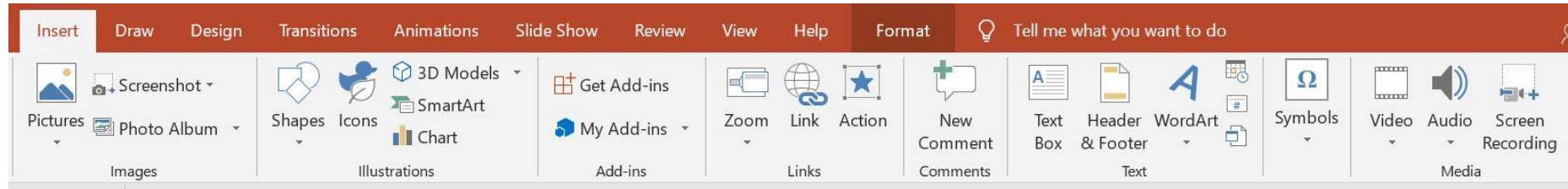
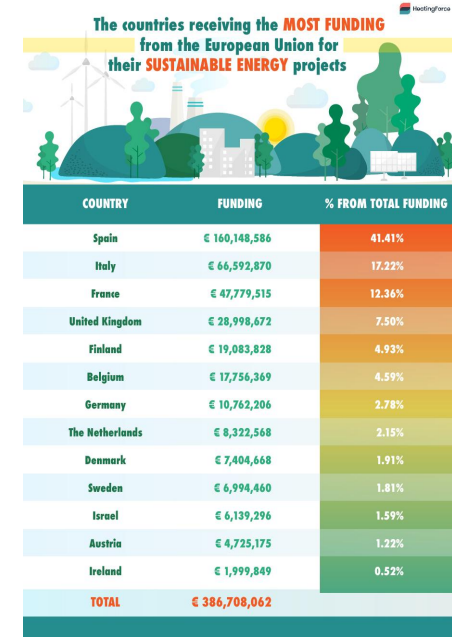
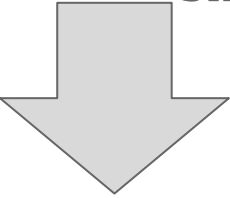
Graphics & Charts: Readability is Key



The graph on the right is easier to read!

Inserting Images

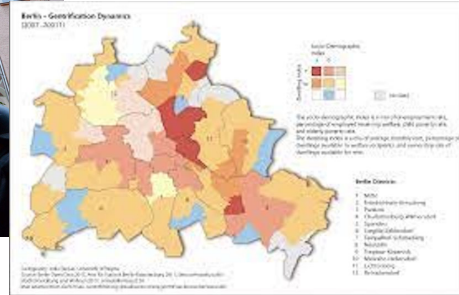
- Use the 'Insert' option to add images: Pictures, Screenshots, Photos; and Illustrations: Shapes, Icons, 3D Models, SmartArt and Charts.



Graphics & Charts: Keep it Simple



VS.



Recording Voiceover for your PowerPoint

Environmental Considerations

- Ideally, find a room with good sound absorption to prevent the “echo effect.”
 - **Yes:** carpet, cushions, bookshelves, clothes (bedrooms, closets)
 - **No:** larger spaces with hard, smooth surfaces (kitchens, bathrooms)
- Take ambient noise into consideration.
 - A/C units, refrigerators, traffic, pets, roommates, loud clothing, etc.
- Put some **distance** between yourself and the microphone
 - Being too close can make the audio too loud or garbled, and being too far can make it too quiet or muffled
 - Know where your microphone is located and keep it clear of papers/other objects.

Environmental Considerations cont'd.

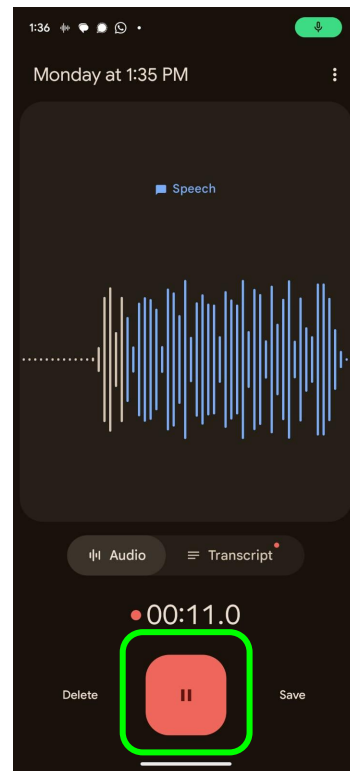
- Use headphones when recording and editing.
 - After you finish editing, listen to the file without headphones to see where the audio is too loud/quiet when played in a space.
-
- Stay hydrated!
 - Keep a drink nearby (water, juice, etc.) to soothe your throat and keep it relaxed.

Recording Devices

- **Laptops:** Windows and Macs have their own pre-installed recording apps that you can use (“Sound Recorder” for Windows, and “Voice Memos” for Mac)
- **Smartphones:** Depending on the phone you have, the app you use will be different—any app that can record audio will work. These free apps are a good starting place:
 - Recorder (Google LLC) for Pixel phones
 - Voice Memos (Apple) for iPhones
 - Samsung Voice Recorder (Samsung) for Galaxy

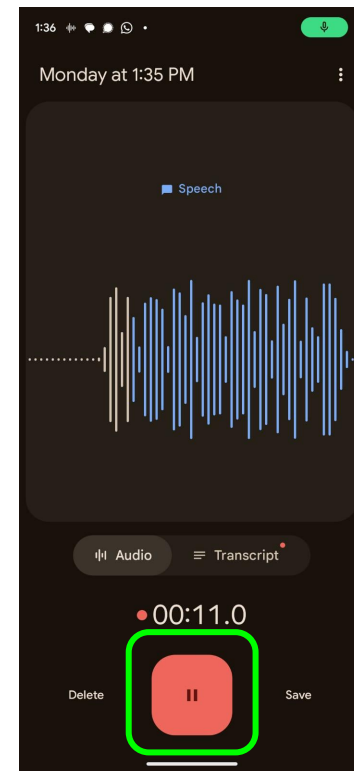
Using Audio Recording Apps (1/2)

- These apps universally use a big, red button to start recording. This slide shows Google's Recorder app, but all of these buttons will be very similar, regardless of the app you are using.
- If you want to take a short break in your recording, you can hit **pause** (highlighted in green). This will stop the recording until you hit record again, but it won't end the recording as a whole.
 - To get to the pause button in Apple Voice Memos, swipe up on the recording while it's running.



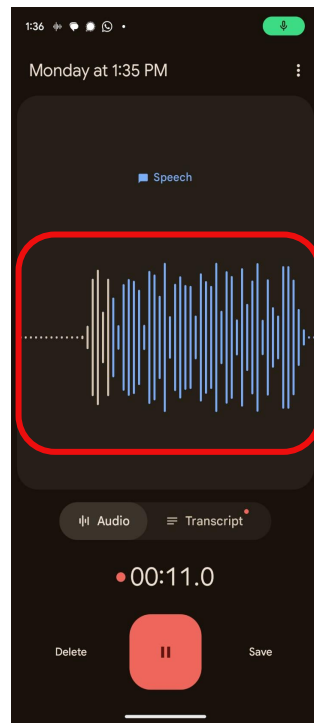
Using Audio Recording Apps (2/2)

- When you're done recording remember to hit **save** or **stop** (often represented by a square). This will end the recording altogether and let you send it to your computer.
- Be mindful of how your data and the recorded audio is stored on different recording apps.



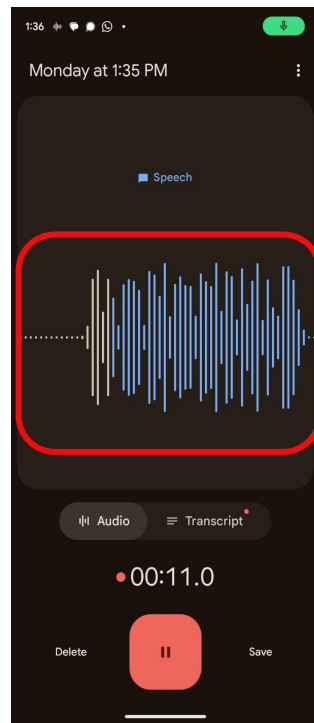
Monitoring Your Recording (1/2)

- While you are recording, the app will show a **waveform** (highlighted in red), which shows the current audio input
- Make sure to check your waveform intermittently as you record (especially at the beginning)



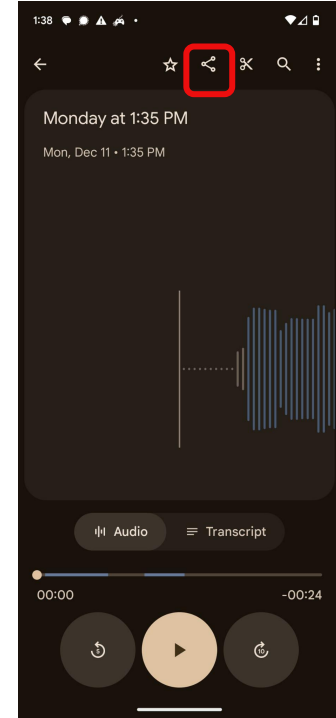
Monitoring Your Recording (2/2)

- If you aren't seeing any waveform or it is very small, the phone is likely not picking up your audio correctly
- The peaks and troughs of the wave show when it is picking up more and less audio. This should generally match the louder and quieter parts of your interview recording, though don't worry if it doesn't seem to be completely precise.



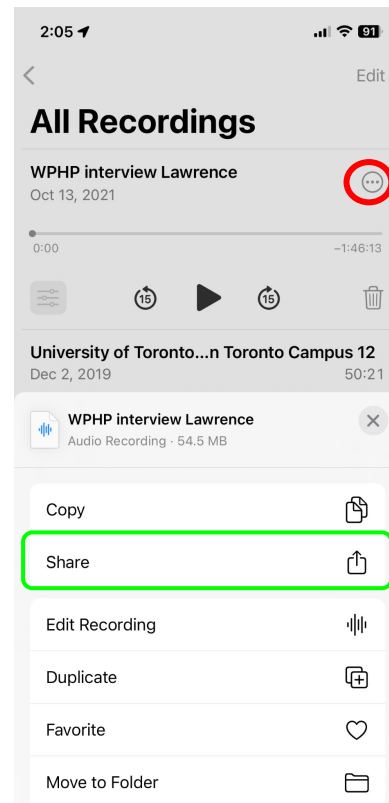
Getting the Audio From Your Android

- The easiest way to get the file from your phone to your computer will be to use the **share** function. Look for a symbol like that highlighted on the right. From the share menu, you will be able to send the file to yourself in various forms, such as email. Sometimes the file size may exceed the limit for email, which is where Google Drive can work better
- As soon as you have files on your computer, you can move on to audio editing!



Getting Audio From Your iPhone

- To get audio out of Voice Memos, click the three dots (highlighted in red) and select “share” (highlighted in green).
- You’ll need to pick a method that works for you:
 - Airdrop and iCloud work.
 - If you download the app for Drive or Dropbox (or similar), you can send the file to those.
 - It will probably be too big a file to email to yourself.



Recording from your laptop

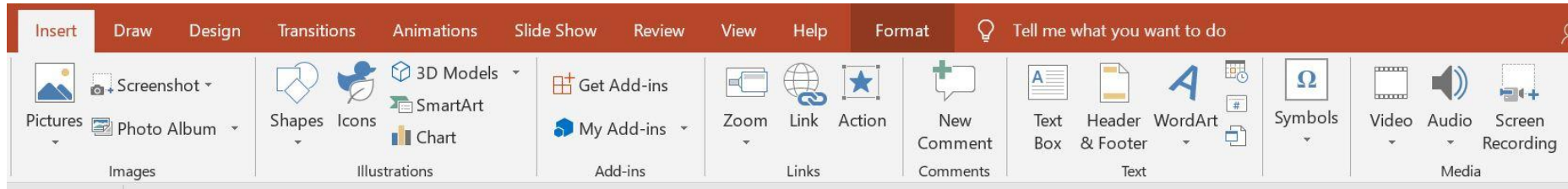
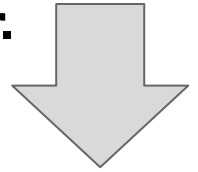
- You

Presentation Tips: Audio, Video, & VoiceOver

Use Audio/Video for Impact

- You can upload audio from your computer or record it within PowerPoint.
- To add video, you can link to an online video or upload one saved to your computer.
- Bear in mind that adding audio and video components may cause display issues during presentations.

Audio and video are available at the top-right when you click “Insert” on the taskbar.

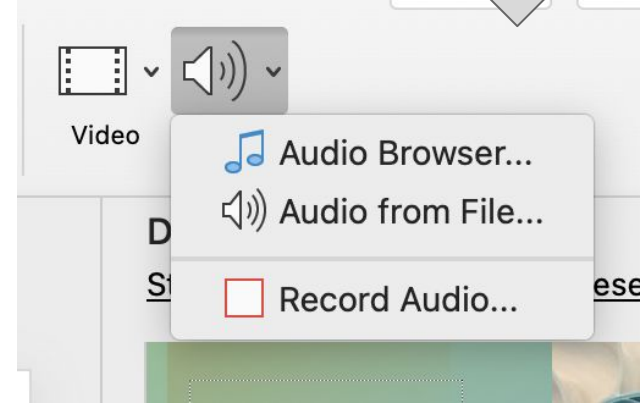


Use Voiceover for Impact



Voiceover is available at the top-right when you click “Insert” on the taskbar.

- Click “Record Audio” on the dropdown menu for “Audio.”
- **Or** select pre-recorded audio from your computer or browser in the dropdown menu.



How Voiceover Looks on a Slide

Voice Over in PowerPoint

Demo for Professor Fuchs' Summer 2021 Class



Voice Over in PowerPoint

Demo for Professor Fuchs' Summer 2021 Class



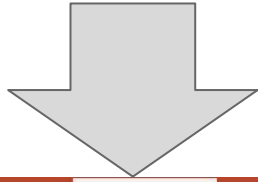
Presentation Tips: Animation Effects & Transitions

Use Animations Judiciously

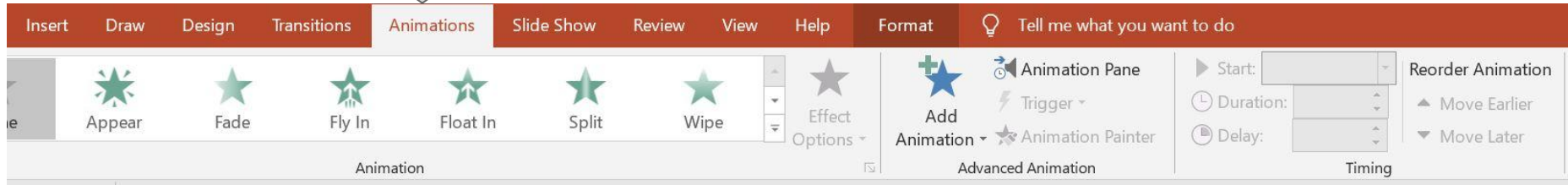
- Animations can add flair to your slide transitions.
- Some types, like Appear, Fade-in, and Fade-out are subtle, while others like Spin or Fly-In can be very busy.
- Using too many of animations can make the presentation look less serious.
 - Animations should only be used if they improve your presentation style and enhance your communication of highly technical or complex information.

Adding Animation Effects

- There are three types of animations: **entrance**, **emphasis**, and **exit**. To use advanced PowerPoint animations, click on the drop-down arrow for “Add Animation” (where the plus sign and blue star icon is located).

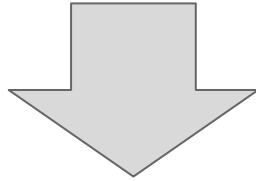


Animations are located here on the taskbar.



Adding Slide Transitions

- Slide transitions animate the movement from one slide to the next. To use PowerPoint transitions, click on the drop-down arrow for “Transitions.”



Transitions are located here on the taskbar.



Advanced PowerPoint: *Designer & Accessibility* **Checker**

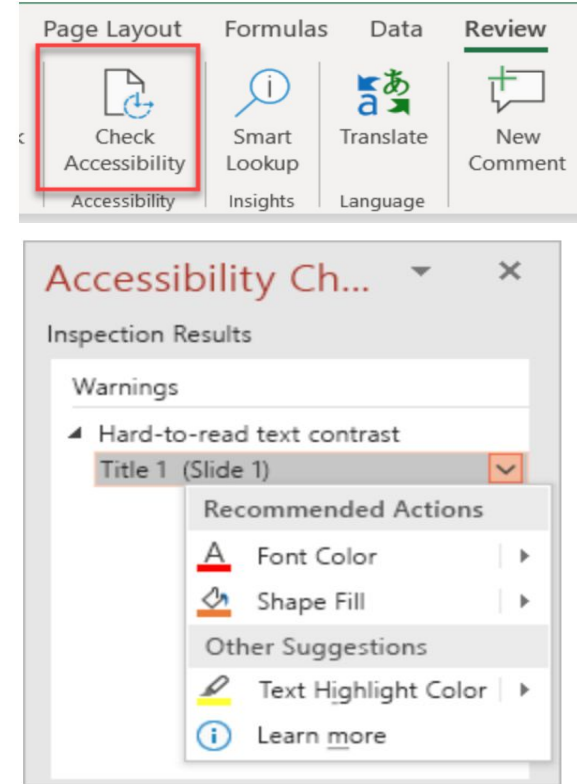
Using PowerPoint *Designer*

- Designer automatically generates design ideas for you to choose from.
 - Insert one or more pictures, a list of items, or a list of dates.
 - The **Designer** panel will open.
 - Select the design you want.
 - You can also bring up Designer by selecting a picture, and then selecting **Design > Design Ideas**.



Improve Accessibility

- **Accessibility Checker** verifies your presentation against a set of standards that identify possible areas of concern. **Find it under the 'Review' tab.**
 - This can be done when you have completed your project, **or**
 - You can get notified of issues as you are working.



For more information on accessibility, please see: <https://bit.ly/accessibility-DITI-handout>

Essential Considerations

Be Consistent & Organized

- **Be intentional** about design choices, and *keep it simple!*
- **Be consistent** in font, font size, color scheme, animation effects, design, formatting, etc.
- Set up **master slides** before you build content slides.
- Organize content with section headers and **signposts**.
- **Choose images/graphics mindfully**, and **don't mix visual types** on a single slide.
- **Limit bullets & text** on slides—keep negative space.

For Further Exploration

[DITI Infographics Handout](#)

[DITI Accessibility Handout](#)

[DITI Data Privacy Handout](#)

[DITI PowerPoint Handout](#)

Thank you!

—**Developed by** Vaishali Kushwaha, Julianna Wessels, Adam Tomasi, and Mel Williams

- For more information on DITI, please see: <https://bit.ly/diti-about>
- Schedule an appointment with us! <https://bit.ly/diti-meeting>
- If you have any questions, contact us at: nulab.info@gmail.com